

I. Fundamentals of the Game (Rules 1-4)

Rule 1 – The Game, Player Conduct and the Rules

Purpose: Rule 1 introduces these central principles of the game for the player:

- *Play the course as you find it and play the ball as it lies.*
- *Play by the Rules and in the spirit of the game.*
- *You are responsible for applying your own penalties if you breach a Rule, so that you cannot gain any potential advantage over your opponent in match play or other players in stroke play.*

1.1 The Game of Golf

Golf is played in a *round* of 18 (or fewer) holes on a *course* by striking a ball with a club.

Each hole starts with a *stroke* from the *teeing area* and ends when the ball is *holed* on the *putting green* (or when the Rules otherwise say the hole is completed).

For each *stroke*, the player:

- Plays the *course* as he or she finds it, and
- Plays the ball as it lies.

But there are exceptions where the Rules allow the player to alter conditions on the *course* and require or allow the player to play the ball from a different place than where it lies.

1.2 Standards of Player Conduct

a. Conduct Expected of All Players

All players are expected to play in the spirit of the game by:

- Acting with integrity – for example, by following the Rules, applying all penalties, and being honest in all aspects of play.
- Showing consideration to others – for example, by playing at a prompt pace, looking out for the safety of others, and not distracting the play of another player.
- Taking good care of the *course* – for example, by replacing divots, smoothing *bunkers*, repairing ball-marks, and not causing unnecessary damage to the *course*.

There is no penalty under the Rules for failing to act in this way, **except** that the *Committee* may disqualify a player for acting contrary to the spirit of the game if it finds that the player has committed serious misconduct.

Penalties other than disqualification may be imposed for player misconduct only if those penalties are adopted as part of a Code of Conduct under Rule 1.2b.

b. Code of Conduct

The *Committee* may set its own standards of player conduct in a Code of Conduct adopted as a Local Rule.

- The Code may include penalties for breach of its standards, such as a one-stroke penalty or the *general penalty*.
- The *Committee* may also disqualify a player for serious misconduct in failing to meet the Code's standards.

See *Committee Procedures, Section 5H* (explaining the standards of player conduct that may be adopted).

1.3 Playing by the Rules

a. Meaning of “Rules”; Terms of the Competition

The “Rules” means:

- Rules 1-24 and the Definitions in these Rules of Golf, and
- Any “Local Rules” the *Committee* adopts for the competition or the *course*.

Players are also responsible for complying with all “Terms of the Competition” adopted by the *Committee* (such as entry requirements, the form and dates of play, the number of *rounds* and the number and order of holes in a *round*).

See *Committee Procedures, Section 5C and Section 8* (Local Rules and full set of authorized Model Local Rules); *Section 5A* (Terms of the Competition).

b. Applying the Rules

(1) *Player Responsibility for Applying the Rules*. Players are responsible for applying the Rules to themselves:

- Players are expected to recognize when they have breached a Rule and to be honest in applying their own penalties.
 - If a player knows that he or she has breached a Rule that involves a penalty and deliberately fails to apply the penalty, the player is **disqualified**.
 - If two or more players deliberately agree to ignore any Rule or penalty they know applies and any of those players have started the *round*, they are **disqualified** (even if they have not yet acted on the agreement).
- When it is necessary to decide questions of fact, a player is responsible for considering not only his or her own knowledge of the facts but also all other information that is reasonably available.
- A player may ask for help with the Rules from a *referee* or the *Committee*, **but** if help is not available in a reasonable time the player must play on and raise the issue with a *referee* or the *Committee* when they become available (see Rule 20.1).

(2) Accepting Player's "Reasonable Judgment" in Determining a Location When Applying the Rules.

- Many Rules require a player to determine a spot, point, line, area or other location under the Rules, such as:
 - Estimating where a ball last crossed the edge of a *penalty area*,
 - Estimating or measuring when *dropping* or placing a ball in taking relief, or
 - *Replacing* a ball on its original spot (whether the spot is known or estimated).
- Such determinations about location need to be made promptly and with care but often cannot be precise.
- So long as the player does what can be reasonably expected under the circumstances to make an accurate determination, the player's reasonable judgment will be accepted even if, after the *stroke* is made, the determination is shown to be wrong by video evidence or other information.
- If a player becomes aware of a wrong determination before the *stroke* is made, it must be corrected (see Rule 14.5).

c. Penalties

(1) Actions Giving Rise to Penalties. A penalty applies when a breach of a Rule results from a player's own actions or the actions of his or her *caddie* (see Rule 10.3c).

A penalty also applies when:

- Another person takes an action that would breach the Rules if taken by the player or *caddie* and that person does so at the player's request or while acting with the player's authority, or
- The player sees another person about to take an action concerning the player's ball or *equipment* that he or she knows would breach the Rules if taken by the player or *caddie* and does not take reasonable steps to object or stop it from happening.

(2) Levels of Penalties. Penalties are meant to cancel out any potential advantage to the player. There are three main penalty levels:

- *One-Stroke Penalty.* This penalty applies in both *match play* and *stroke play* under certain Rules where either (a) the potential advantage from a breach is minor or (b) a player takes penalty relief by playing a ball from a different place than where the original ball lies.
- *General Penalty (Loss of Hole in Match Play, Two-Stroke Penalty in Stroke Play).* This penalty applies for a breach of most Rules, where the potential advantage is more significant than where only one penalty stroke applies.
- *Disqualification.* In both *match play* and *stroke play*, a player may be disqualified from the competition for certain actions or Rule breaches involving serious

misconduct (see Rule 1.2) or where the potential advantage is too significant for the player's score to be considered valid.

(3) No Discretion to Vary Penalties. Penalties need to be applied only as provided in the Rules:

- Neither a player nor the *Committee* has authority to apply penalties in a different way, and
- A wrong application of a penalty or a failure to apply a penalty may stand only if it is too late to correct it (see Rules 20.1b(2)-(4), 20.2d and 20.2e).

In *match play*, the player and *opponent* may agree how to decide a Rules issue so long as they do not deliberately agree to apply the Rules in the wrong way (see Rule 20.1b(1)).

(4) Applying Penalties to Multiple Breaches of the Rules. If a player breaches multiple Rules or the same Rule multiple times before an intervening event happens (such as making a *stroke* or becoming aware of the breach), the penalty that applies depends on what the player did:

- When Breaches Resulted from Unrelated Acts. The player gets a separate penalty for each breach.
- When Breaches Resulted from a Single Act or Related Acts. The player gets only one penalty; **but** if the act or acts breached multiple Rules involving different penalties, the higher-level penalty applies. For example:
 - Multiple Procedural Breaches. If a player's single act or related acts breach more than one of the procedural requirements for *marking*, lifting, cleaning, *dropping*, *replacing* or placing a ball where the penalty is one stroke, such as both lifting a ball without *marking* its spot and cleaning the lifted ball when not allowed, the player gets **one penalty stroke in total**.
 - Playing Incorrectly Substituted Ball from a Wrong Place. In *stroke play*, if a player plays a *substituted* ball when not allowed in breach of Rule 6.3b and also plays that ball from a *wrong place* in breach of Rule 14.7a, the player gets **two penalty strokes in total**.
 - Combined Procedural and Substitution/Wrong Place Breaches: In *stroke play*, if a player's single act or related acts breach one or more procedural requirements where the penalty is one stroke and also breach one or both of the Rules against playing an incorrectly *substituted* ball and playing from a *wrong place*, the player gets **two penalty strokes in total**.

But any penalty strokes a player gets for taking penalty relief (such as a one-stroke penalty under Rules 17.1, 18.1 and 19.2) are always applied in addition to any other penalties.

Rule 2 – The Course

Purpose: Rule 2 introduces the basic things every player should know about the course:

- There are five defined areas of the course, and
- There are several types of defined objects and conditions that can interfere with play.

It is important to know the area of the course where the ball lies and the status of any interfering objects and conditions, because they often affect the player's options for playing the ball or taking relief.

2.1 Course Boundaries and Out of Bounds

Golf is played on a *course* whose boundaries are set by the *Committee*. Areas not on the *course* are *out of bounds*.

2.2 Defined Areas of the Course

There are five *areas of the course*.

a. The General Area

The *general area* covers the entire *course* **except** for the four specific *areas of the course* described in Rule 2.2b.

It is called the “general” area because:

- It covers most of the *course* and is where a player's ball will most often be played until the ball reaches the *putting green*.
- It includes every type of ground and growing or attached objects found in that area, such as fairway, rough and trees.

b. The Four Specific Areas

Certain Rules apply specifically to the four *areas of the course* that are not in the *general area*:

- The *teeing area* the player must use in starting the hole he or she is playing (Rule 6.2),
- All *penalty areas* (Rule 17),
- All *bunkers* (Rule 12), and
- The *putting green* of the hole the player is playing (Rule 13).

c. Determining Area of Course Where Ball Lies

The *area of the course* where a player's ball lies affects the Rules that apply in playing the ball or taking relief.

A ball is always treated as lying in only one *area of the course*:

- If part of the ball is in both the *general area* and one of the four specific *areas of the course*, it is treated as lying in that specific *area of the course*.
- If part of the ball is in two specific *areas of the course*, it is treated as lying in the specific area that comes first in this order: *penalty area, bunker, putting green*.

2.3 Objects or Conditions That Can Interfere with Play

Certain Rules may give free relief (relief with no penalty) from interference by certain defined objects or conditions, such as:

- *Loose impediments* (Rule 15.1),
- *Movable obstructions* (Rule 15.2), and
- *Abnormal course conditions*, which are *animal holes, ground under repair, immovable obstructions* and *temporary water* (Rule 16.1).

But there is no free relief from *boundary objects* or *integral objects* that interfere with play.

2.4 No Play Zones

A *no play zone* is a defined part of an *abnormal course condition* (see Rule 16.1f) or a *penalty area* (see Rule 17.1e) where play is not allowed.

A player must take relief when:

- His or her ball is in a *no play zone*, or
- A *no play zone* interferes with his or her area of intended *stance* or area of intended swing in playing a ball outside the *no play zone* (see Rules 16.1f and 17.1e).

See Committee Procedures, Section 5H(1) (a Code of Conduct may tell players to stay out of a *no play zone* entirely).

Rule 3 – The Competition

Purpose: Rule 3 covers the three central elements of all golf competitions:

- *Playing either match play or stroke play,*
- *Playing either as an individual or with a partner as part of a side, and*
- *Scoring either by gross scores (no handicap strokes applied) or net scores (handicap strokes applied).*

3.1 Central Elements of Every Competition

a. Form of Play: Match Play or Stroke Play

(1) Match Play or Regular Stroke Play. These are very different forms of play:

- In *match play* (see Rule 3.2), a player and an *opponent* compete against each other based on holes won, lost or tied.
- In the regular form of *stroke play* (see Rule 3.3), all players compete with one another based on the total score – that is, adding up each player's total number of strokes (including *strokes* made and penalty strokes) on each hole in all *rounds*.

Most of the Rules apply in both forms of play, but certain Rules apply in only one or the other.

See **Committee Procedures, Section 6C** (considerations for the *Committee* if it runs a competition that combines the two forms of play in a single *round*).

(2) Other Forms of Stroke Play. Rule 21 covers other forms of *stroke play* (*Stableford*, *Maximum Score* and *Par/Bogey*) that use a different scoring method. Rules 1-20 apply in these forms of play, as modified by Rule 21.

b. How Players Compete: Playing as an Individual or as Partners

Golf is played either by individual players competing on their own or by *partners* competing together as a *side*.

Although Rules 1-20 focus on individual play, they also apply:

- In competitions involving *partners* (*Foursomes* and *Four-Ball*), as modified by Rules 22 and 23, and
- In team competitions, as modified by Rule 24.

c. How Players Score: Gross Scores or Net Scores

(1) Scratch Competitions. In a scratch competition:

- The player's "gross score" for a hole or the *round* is his or her total number of strokes (including *strokes* made and penalty strokes).

- The player's handicap is not applied.

(2) Handicap Competitions. In a handicap competition:

- The player's "net score" for a hole or the *round* is the gross score adjusted for the player's handicap strokes.
- This is done so that players of differing abilities can compete in a fair way.

3.2 Match Play

Purpose: Match play has specific Rules (particularly about concessions and giving information about the number of strokes taken) because the player and opponent:

- *Compete solely against each other on every hole,*
- *Can see each other's play, and*
- *Can protect their own interests.*

a. Result of Hole and Match

(1) Winning a Hole. A player wins a hole when:

- The player completes the hole in fewer strokes (including *strokes* made and penalty strokes) than the *opponent*,
- The *opponent* concedes the hole, or
- The *opponent* gets the *general penalty* (loss of hole).

If the *opponent's* ball in motion needs to be *holed* to tie the hole and the ball is deliberately deflected or stopped by any person at a time when there is no reasonable chance it can be *holed* (such as when the ball has rolled past the *hole* and will not roll back there), the result of the hole has been decided and the player wins the hole (see Rule 11.2a, Exception).

(2) Tying a Hole. A hole is tied (also known as "halved") when:

- The player and *opponent* complete the hole in the same number of strokes (including *strokes* made and penalty strokes), or
- The player and *opponent* agree to treat the next stroke, a hole or the match as tied (**but** this is allowed only after at least one of the players has made a *stroke* to begin the hole).

(3) Winning a Match. A player wins a match when:

- The player leads the *opponent* by more holes than remain to be played,
- The *opponent* concedes the match, or
- The *opponent* is disqualified.

(4) Extending a Tied Match. If a match is tied after the final hole:

- The match is extended one hole at a time until there is a winner. See Rule 5.1 (an extended match is a continuation of the same *round*, not a new *round*).
- The holes are played in the same order as in the *round*, unless the *Committee* sets a different order.

But the Terms of the Competition may say that the match will end in a tie rather than be extended.

(5) When Result is Final. The result of a match becomes final in the way stated by the *Committee* (which should be set out in the Terms of the Competition), such as:

- When the result is recorded on an official scoreboard or other identified place, or
- When the result is reported to a person identified by the *Committee*.

See **Committee Procedures, Section 5A(7)** (recommendations on how the result of a match becomes final).

b. Concessions

(1) Player May Concede Stroke, Hole or Match. A player may concede the *opponent's* next *stroke*, a hole or the match:

- Conceding Next Stroke. This is allowed any time before the *opponent's* next *stroke* is made.
 - The *opponent* has then completed the hole with a score that includes that conceded *stroke*, and the ball may be removed by anyone.
 - A concession made while the *opponent's* ball is still in motion after the previous *stroke* applies to the *opponent's* next *stroke*, unless the ball is *holed* (in which case the concession does not matter).
 - The player may concede the *opponent's* next *stroke* by deflecting or stopping the *opponent's* ball in motion only if that is done specifically to concede the next *stroke* and only when there is no reasonable chance the ball can be *holed*.
- Conceding a Hole. This is allowed any time before the hole is completed (see Rule 6.5), including before the players start the hole.
- Conceding the Match. This is allowed any time before the result of the match is decided (see Rules 3.2a(3) and (4)), including before the players start the match.

(2) How Concessions Are Made. A concession is made only when clearly communicated:

- This can be done either verbally or by an action that clearly shows the player's intent to concede the *stroke*, the hole or the match (such as making a gesture).
- If the *opponent* lifts his or her ball in breach of a Rule because of a reasonable misunderstanding that the player's statement or action was a concession of the next

stroke or the hole or match, there is no penalty and the ball must be *replaced* on its original spot (which if not known must be estimated) (see Rule 14.2).

A concession is final and cannot be declined or withdrawn.

c. Applying Handicaps in Handicap Match

(1) Declaring Handicaps. The player and *opponent* should tell each other their handicaps before the match.

If a player declares a wrong handicap either before or during the match and does not correct the mistake before the *opponent* makes his or her next *stroke*:

- Declared Handicap Too High. The player is **disqualified** if this affects the number of strokes the player gives or gets. If it does not, there is no penalty.
- Declared Handicap Too Low. There is no penalty and the player must play off the declared lower handicap.

(2) Holes Where Handicap Strokes Applied.

- Handicap strokes are given by hole, and the lower net score wins the hole.
- If a tied match is extended, handicap strokes are given by hole in the same way as in the *round* (unless the *Committee* sets a different way of doing so).

Each player is responsible for knowing the holes where he or she gives or gets handicap strokes, based on the stroke index allocation set by the *Committee* (which is usually found on the scorecard).

If the players mistakenly apply handicap strokes on a hole, the agreed result of the hole stands, unless the players correct that mistake in time (see Rule 3.2d(3)).

d. Responsibilities of Player and Opponent

(1) Telling Opponent about Number of Strokes Taken. At any time during play of a hole or after the hole is completed, the *opponent* may ask the player for the number of strokes (including *strokes* made and penalty strokes) the player has taken on the hole.

This is to allow the *opponent* to decide how to play the next *stroke* and the rest of the hole, or to confirm the result of the hole just completed.

When asked for the number of strokes taken, or when giving that information without being asked:

- The player must give the right number of strokes taken.
- A player who fails to respond to the *opponent's* request is treated as giving the wrong number of strokes taken.

The player gets the **general penalty (loss of hole)** if he or she gives the *opponent* the wrong number of strokes taken, unless the player corrects that mistake in time:

- Wrong Number of Strokes Given While Playing Hole. The player must give the right number of strokes taken before the *opponent* makes another *stroke* or takes a similar action (such as conceding the player's next *stroke* or the hole).
- Wrong Number of Strokes Given After Hole Completed. The player must give the right number of strokes taken:
 - Before either player makes a *stroke* to begin another hole or takes a similar action (such as conceding the next hole or the match) or,
 - For the final hole of the match, before the result of the match is final (see Rule 3.2a(5)).

Exception – No Penalty If No Effect on Result of Hole: If the player gives the wrong number of strokes taken after a hole is completed but this does not affect the *opponent's* understanding of whether the hole was won, lost or tied, there is no penalty.

(2) Telling Opponent about Penalty. When a player gets a penalty:

- The player must tell the *opponent* about that penalty as soon as reasonably possible, taking into account how near the player is to the *opponent* and other practical factors.
- This requirement applies even if the player does not know about the penalty (because players are expected to recognize when they have breached a Rule).

If the player fails to do so and does not correct that mistake before the *opponent* makes another *stroke* or takes a similar action (such as conceding the player's next *stroke* or the hole), the player gets the **general penalty (loss of hole)**.

Exception – No Penalty When Opponent Knew of Player's Penalty: If the *opponent* knew that the player had a penalty, such as when seeing the player obviously take penalty relief, the player gets no penalty for failing to tell the *opponent* about it.

(3) Knowing Match Score. The players are expected to know the match score – that is, whether one of them leads by a certain number of holes ("holes up" in the match) or the match is tied (also known as "all square").

If the players mistakenly agree on a wrong match score:

- They may correct the match score before either player makes a *stroke* to begin another hole or, for the final hole, before the result of the match is final (see Rule 3.2a(5)).
- If not corrected in that time, that wrong match score becomes the actual match score.

Exception – When Player Requests Ruling in Time: If the player makes a timely request for a ruling (see Rule 20.1b), and it is found that the *opponent* either (1) gave the wrong number of strokes taken or (2) failed to tell the player about a penalty, the wrong match score must be corrected.